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IN REGIONS

**WHERE POVERTY,
INFORMALITY AND
UNDERDEVELOPMENT
PERSIST, A HARD
SHIFT TO DEGROWTH
WITHOUT SYSTEMIC
SAFETY NETS COULD
BE DESTABILISING**

INDIA NEEDS INCLUSIVE WEALTH

Lifestyle for the Environment, or LiFE, calls for sustainable lifestyles rooted in responsible consumption, ecological mindfulness, and alignment with nature's regenerative capacities

GROWTH FETISHISM, a phenomenon that views GDP growth as the ultimate measure of economic progress, has characterised the development paradigm of the global South. The BRICS nations, including India, epitomise this vision. From a paradigmatic perspective, this vision is reductionist, to say the least—the complex multidimensional notion of development is reduced to a single numerical variable. Such unbridled, mindless pursuit of growth often blurs the costs of growth, namely, accelerating climate change, deepening inequality, and a degrading ecosystem.

Climate change is not fundamentally an environmental problem, but a developmental one. It emerges from the systemic failure to factor in the environmental and social costs of unbridled growth. And yet, in the aftermath of the Covid-19 pandemic, most recovery strategies in the Global South have reinforced the same old blueprint: high capital expenditure, infrastructure expansion, and resource-intensive urbanisation. India, for instance, increased its capital expenditure outlay by over 35% in the immediate post-pandemic year 2022–23 compared to pre-pandemic levels. It is not that such expansions are not needed. India needs physical capital expansion to promote pri-

vate investment, given that its past growth has largely been driven by private consumption. But such investments often come at the cost of natural ecosystems—forests, wetlands, and grasslands.

This paradox is stark: while nations pledge net-zero emissions and accelerate the transition to renewables, they simultaneously clear vast tracts of land that act as carbon sinks for construction and industrial expansion. Such ecosystem destruction undermines the very climate mitigation efforts those transitions seek to support.

The reductionist definition of “Green Transition” as a shift from fossil fuels to renewable energy ignores the fact that lifestyle choices, consumption patterns, and land-use practices are equally crucial in determining the success of any climate strategy. Green growth—often presented as a win-win for the economy and ecology—assumes that GDP can be decoupled from natural resource use. However, studies like those by Ward and colleagues in 2016 confirm that such decoupling is neither empirically substantiated nor economically sustainable in the long term.

Given this, Prime Minister Narendra Modi's call for a global mass movement through LiFE—Lifestyle